

ELI5: why do people make a big deal of ai consuming liters of water but not about using tik tok and apps like that?

Posted by u/morcatka • 0 points • 99 comments

I'm trying to explain to my parents that they shouldn't use ai for things google can find them and this is the point they keep bringing up. It pisses me off because I don't have a answer.

Comments

u/Free_Dimension1459 • 1 points • 2025-07-25 19:51 UTC

Creating a 1 minute AI video consumes about as much energy as watching TikTok nonstop for 2 hours.

I don't know the details of water use here, but I assume it also takes at least 100 times as much cooling as watching TikTok.

u/Words4theFiringSquad • 2 points • 2025-07-25 18:11 UTC

Everyone saying how AI is much worse than "normal" computing but in reality every business that exists has servers, sitting in a rack, in a facility that uses a ton of resources to maintain environmental levels and protect from disasters. Others in this thread are saying that Facebook and other social media companies are "easy to run" have no idea what they're talking about. I've seen a Facebook datacenter. It looks like a mile long starship with water tanks and house sized generators every hundred feet. There's no doubt new technologies like AI are going to need more resources, and we should work to find sustainable ways to meet those needs, but the ecological angle of AI doesn't sit well with me as someone who's seen the scale of current tech infrastructure firsthand.

People are targeting AI because it's the new hot thing and there are legitimate worries about new technologies and their impact. I don't see any reason why you should discourage people (particularly aging people) from using AI searches. It's really a disservice to tell people not to keep up with current technology trends. There's a reason why we have old folks today who are losing their life savings to rudimentary scamming techniques. The best way to protect against the threats of new technologies is to understand those technologies.

u/Bob_Sconce • 2 points • 2025-07-25 18:06 UTC

Because AI is relatively new and the TOTAL energy used by AI, including training and querying, is enormous and is being added on to all those previous uses.

The current estimate is that a single AI query uses 2.9 watt-hours of energy. (That's about 10x what a

Google Search does.) IN comparison, a PS5 uses about 200W while gaming. So, if your parents make a couple dozen AI queries a day, they're still well under what your little brother uses in an hour while playing Fortnite, You're really better off getting to turn their A/C up.

TRAINING an AI model uses just an enormous crapload of power, but once the model is trained, individual queries aren't horrible. The problem is more in the aggregate -- your parents aren't using much electricity, but multiply them by billions of people, and the total effect is massive.

u/sdwennnermark • 2 points • 2025-07-25 18:03 UTC

They make a big deal out of it because they don't have any idea what they are talking about. AI usage does not consume vast amounts of water.

Source : I am a building automation programmer and I design Hydronic systems that cool data centers and various other facilities like AI facilities and these are designed to be closed loops so the water that's in the system stays in the system and goes around in a circle over and over, heating up and cooling down. Same water used, it's not consumed.

What's even better is once the water is hot that hot water is then used in a heat recovery chiller that transfers the thermal energy for some processes and gives back cold water again.

All very efficient almost no water loss.